3.4.2 The PageModel as a view model

If there is one thing that consistently seems to confuse developers who are new to any form of MVC with ASP.NET, it is the concept of a view model—what it is, its purpose, and how to create one. In essence, a view model is an extremely simple thing. It is a class that encapsulates the data required for a particular view or page. Conceptually, it performs the same function as a static database view. A view model contains a subset of data from one or, usually, more objects.

Think about an order summary page on a website, for example. It usually contains a subset of the details related to the product or service that you are ordering—perhaps, just its identifier, name, and price. It might also include your name, billing address, and a check box to indicate that you also want to ship to that address. Those pieces of information will come from the Products table and the Customers table in the website's database. However, none of the rest of the information in those database tables is required by the order summary view. The order summary page doesn't display the customer's password or the date they created their account, for example. Nor does it show in-house details of the product that might be stored in the Products table, such as the supplier's details or the reorder level.

Figure 3.8 provides an indication of how little of the total information held by the Products and Customers tables is required for the view. This subset of data forms the basis of your `OrderSummaryViewModel`—the model for the order summary view, which might look like the content of listing 3.24.